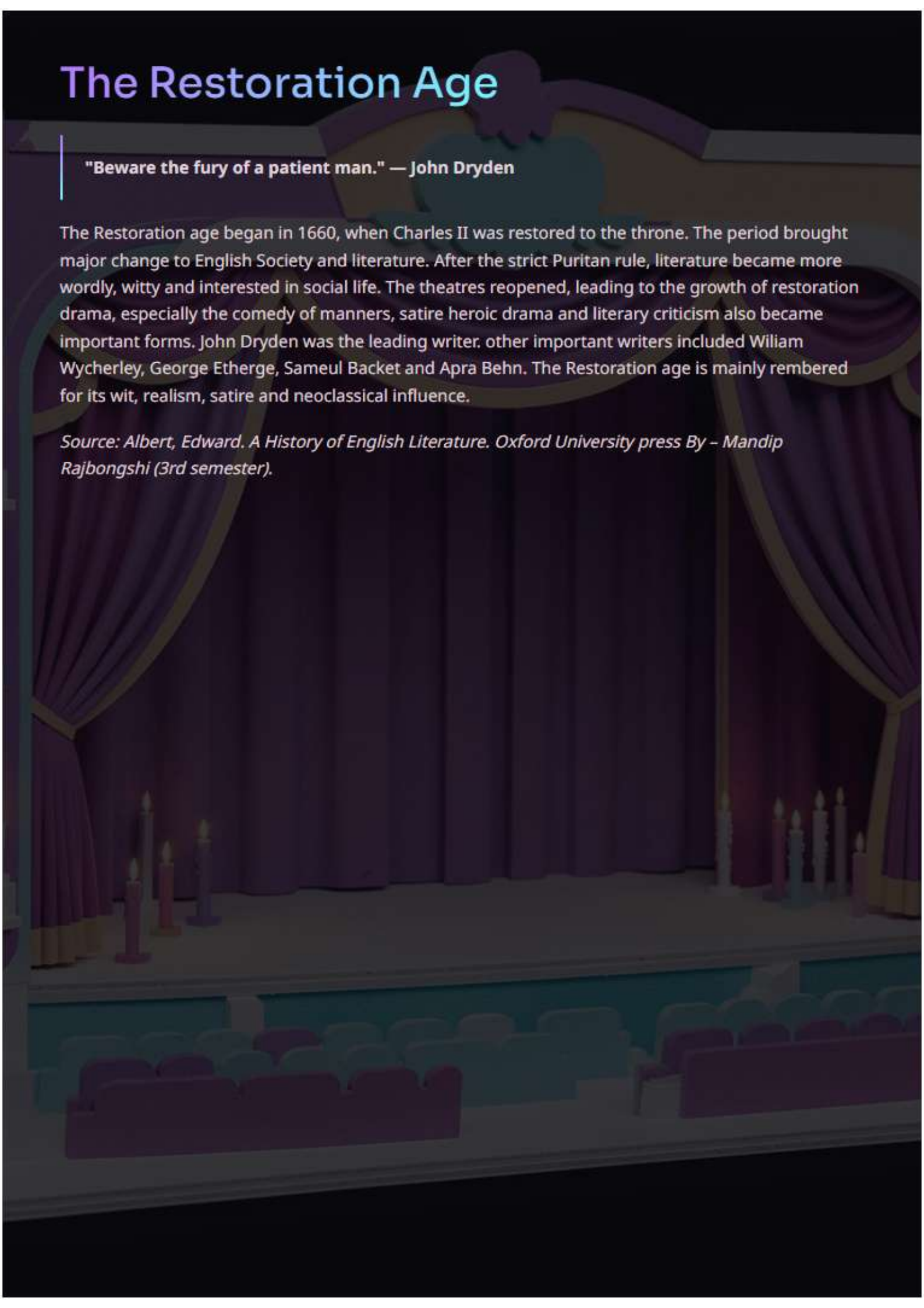


The Restoration Age

"Beware the fury of a patient man." — John Dryden

The Restoration age began in 1660, when Charles II was restored to the throne. The period brought major change to English Society and literature. After the strict Puritan rule, literature became more worldly, witty and interested in social life. The theatres reopened, leading to the growth of restoration drama, especially the comedy of manners, satire heroic drama and literary criticism also became important forms. John Dryden was the leading writer. other important writers included William Wycherley, George Etherge, Sameul Backet and Apra Behn. The Restoration age is mainly rembered for its wit, realism, satire and neoclassical influence.

Source: Albert, Edward. A History of English Literature. Oxford University press By – Mandip Rajbongshi (3rd semester).



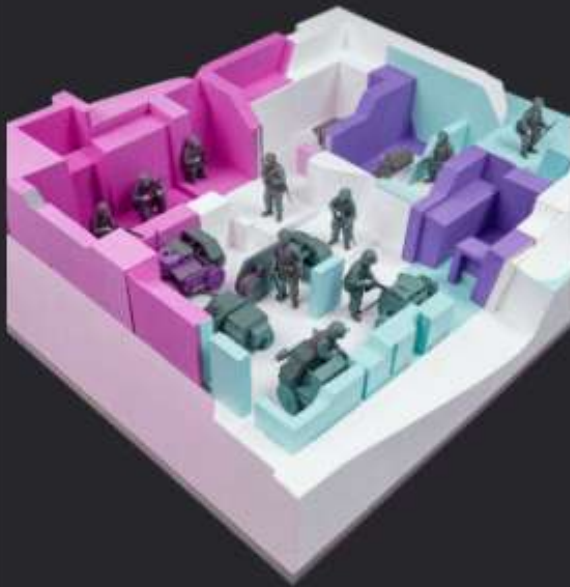
Georgian Movement & War Poetry

The Georgian movement was a literary movement in English poetry that developed in the early twentieth century during the reign of King George V. The Georgian poets reacted against the artificial and exaggerated style of Victorian poetry and preferred simplicity. Prominent poets included Rupert Brooke, Walter de la Mare and Edward Thomas. Its poets preferred clear and natural expression.

With the outbreak of WWI (1914-1918) poetry increasingly reflected patriotism, sacrifice, disillusionment and the harsh realities of war. During WWII (1939-1945) writers continued exploring war, fear, destruction and its psychological impacts. Major writers associated with this period include Keith Douglas, Auden and Louis Mac Neice.

Thus, war literature gradually shifted from romantic idealism to realism, criticism and disillusionment.

Source: Albert, Edward. A History of English Literature. Oxford University Press.



Old English Period

Old English or Anglo-Saxon literature, began with the settlements of the Angles, Saxons and Jutes in Britain, and ended with the Norman Conquest of 1066 – laying the foundation of English Literature.

Anglo – Saxon society was build on feudal loyalty: the lord gave protection and leadership, while warriors gave service and courage – a bond clearly seen in Beowulf, at Heorot, the great hall. The ideal hero was brave, strong, loyal and ready to face danger for his people.

Religion, too, shaped the age – Early Germanic Paganism gradually blended with Christianity, giving the literature each distinct dual character

German Influence and Transition

Strong Germanic roots shaped early English language and literature

Paved the way for Chaucer's contribution to English Language, literature and poetry in the age that followed

Source: Albert, Edward. A History of English Literature. Oxford University press.



Middle English Period (1066–1500 AD)

The middle English period (1066-1500AD) began after the Normand conquest of England. The conquest brought strong France influence on Englishman, language, manners, culture and literature, while Latin also remained influential. Literature expanded from mainly religious writings to themes of romance, Chivalry, morality, satire and everyday life.

Geoffrey Chaucher (1343-1400), known as the father of English poetry. He was the greatest poet of the period. His major work's "The Canterbury Tales and Troilus and Criseyde, Showcase strong telling, characterisation, humour and social observation. Through his works, Chaucher helped established English as a major literary language and laid the foundation for later English Poetry and Prose."

Source: Albert, Edward. A History of English Literature. Oxford University press.



Victorian Literature: Science, Society, and Fate

spanning Queen Victoria's reign from 1837 to 1901, this era witnessed England surge into modernity: factories roared, empires expanded, and science began to redraw the boundaries of belief. The Victorian Age was marked by opposite forces - Science and religion, material progress and moral decadence.

Figures like Charles Dickens gave voice to the neglected classes through "Oliver Twist" and "Great Expectations", exposing social injustice and the human cost of progress and Thomas Hardy explored lives caught between changing values, fading faith, and fate.

*Source: Albert Edward. A History of English Literature.
Oxford University press*

*Source: Albert, Edward. A History of English Literature.
Oxford University press.*



The Theatre of Absurd

The Theatre of the Absurd is a modern form of drama that became popular after World War ii. The term was coined by Martin Esslin in 1960. It present life as meaningless and uncertainty.

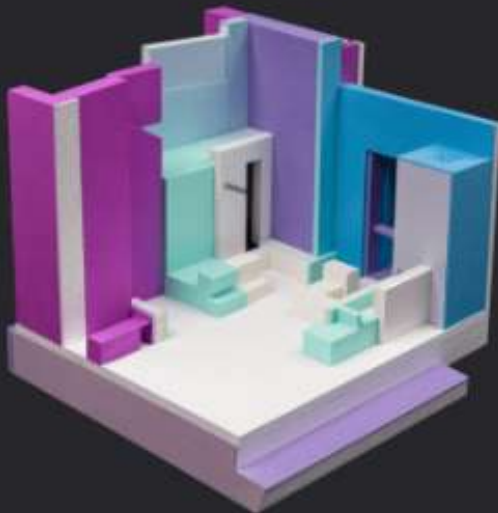
Unlike traditional drama, absurdist plays often have no clear plot or ending. Moreover, they use repetition, silence, illogical and dark humor to show human life confusion and loneliness.

Namely Samuel Beckett's "Waiting for Godot" shows two man waiting endlessly for Godot, who never arrives.

Thus, the Theatre of the Absurd presents the uncertainty and meaninglessness of human life through illogical situations and miss communication.

Source: Albert Edward. A History of English Literature. Oxford University press.

By- Ritul das (5th semester).



Neoclassicism

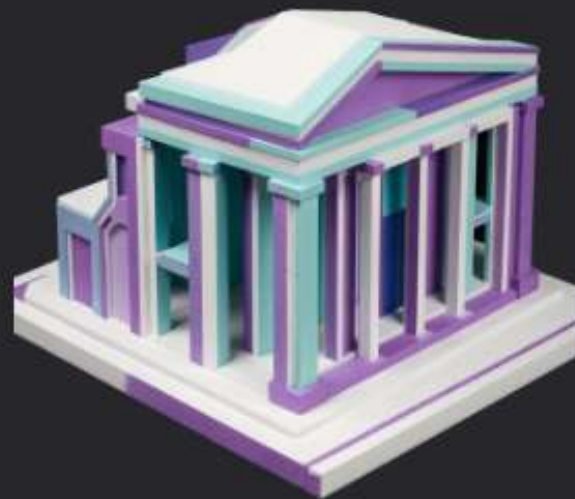
Neoclassicism (1660–1798) reformed society by reviving Greco-Roman principles of order, reason, and restraint during the Enlightenment. Alexander Pope's "The Rape of the Lock," he satirized elite society's trivialities to encourage moral responsibility. His philosophical poetry, including *An Essay on Man*, articulated the period's aesthetic and moral tenets, urging individuals to recognize their duty in a divinely ordered world and to use formal mastery to restore cultural ethics.

**"What dire offence from amorous causes springs,
what mighty contests rise from trivial things."**

— The Rape of the Lock by Alexander Pope

*Source: Poetry Foundation – Alexander Pope;
Neoclassical Literature (PPT); Alexander Pope – The Rape
of the Lock, Canto 1*

*Source: Albert, Edward. A History of English Literature.
Oxford University press.*



Civil War Period

The Caroline Era, named after Carlous 1 (Latin for Charles 1). It was marked by growing conflict between the Royalists, and Parliamentarians, eventually leading to the English Civil War. These tensions strengthened the influence of puritanism.

As the civil war ended with the parliamentary victory under Oliver Cornwell, puritan influence became dominant during the common wealth and Interregnum (1649-1660). The Caroline and puritan phases are closely linked, moving from royal religious conflict to puritan influence and political change.

Source: Albert Edward. A History of English Literature. Oxford university press.



The Romantic Age (1798–1832)

"Poetry is the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings... recollected in tranquillity." — William Wordsworth.

In the autumn of 1798, two young poets changed English literature forever. William Wordsworth and Samuel Taylor Coleridge. Published a slim volume of poems called *Lyrical Ballads* — and with it Romantic age was born.

Two Poets, Two Worlds

Wordsworth looked to the hills, the daffodils, the shepherds — finding the sacred in simple, rustic life.

Coleridge looked to the shadows, the supernatural, the mysterious — giving us the unforgettable *Ancient Mariner*.

The Preface (1802) — 'Romanticism's Manifesto'

In the Preface to the *Lyrical Ballads*, Wordsworth then declared his revolution:

- Poetry should speak in the "language really used by men"
- The poet is simply "a man speaking to men"
- True poetry flows from feeling not formal rules

BIOGRAPHIA LITERARIA LITARARIA (1817) — THE PHILOSOPHER SPEAKS

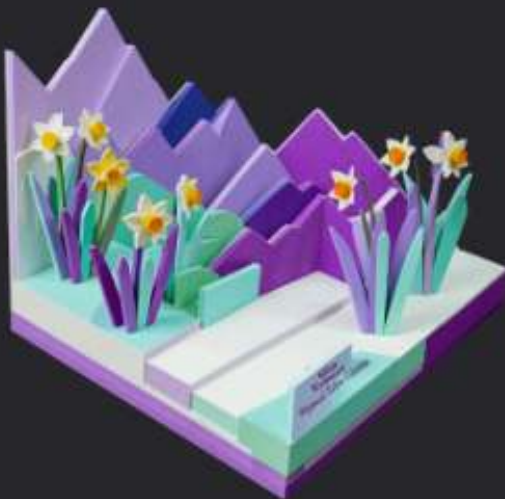
Years later, Coleridge added his voice with *Biographia literaria*, gifting literature one timeless idea:

"Imagination is not mere fancy — It is the living, shaping power that turns perception into art."

A revolution that began with a single book of poems — and never really ended.

— Trisha Hazarika

Source: Edward Albert, *History of English Literature*, Oxford University Press; William Wordsworth, *Preface to Lyrical Ballads* (1802); S.T. Coleridge, *Biographia Literaria* (1817).



The Age of Shakespeare: Elizabethan, 1558 to 1603

"All the world's a stage, and all the men and women merely players." — William Shakespeare.

The Elizabethan and Jacobean eras saw English literature and theatre flourish like never before. At the heart of it stood William Shakespeare, the age's most celebrated writer. Through his poems, love became poetry, ambition became tragedy, and human nature became timeless drama. His plays captured the joys, complexities, and flaws of people with remarkable depth, a literary treasure that still speaks to us.

His Literary Treasures

Tragedies

Hamlet, Macbeth, Othello.

Comedies

Twelfth Night, As You Like It.

Histories

Henry VI, Richard II, Richard III.

Poetry

154 sonnets, *Venus and Adonis*.

The Golden Age of Drama

The Elizabethan Age gave English literature its greatest gift: the flourishing of drama. Public theatres like the Globe rose along the Thames, drawing audiences from every class.

